

GST102

Use of English and Communication Skills II

Course Summary

Ubora World Study Companion

About This Summary

This summary condenses the core ideas of GST102 (Use of English and Communication Skills II) into a quick-reference study guide. It covers all 4 modules and 20 study units: paragraph and letter writing, reports and summarising, sounds and public speaking, and English grammar. Use it to revise before practicing with the CBT question bank, not as a replacement for the full course material.

Module 1: Writing Paragraphs and Formal Letters I

Writing Paragraphs: Topic Sentence and Coherence

A paragraph is unified by a central, controlling idea, usually expressed in a topic sentence most often placed at the start of the paragraph. A well-written paragraph is also coherent — it takes the reader logically and smoothly from one idea to the next — and transitional devices (such as "however," "therefore," "similarly," and "firstly") act as signposts that show how sentences relate to one another.

Development of Paragraphs: Illustration and Description

Paragraphs can be developed using illustration (giving concrete examples to support a point) and description (painting a vivid picture with sensory or specific detail). Mastering these techniques is a step toward becoming an effective, versatile writer.

Development of Paragraphs: Cause and Effect and Definitions

Beyond illustration and description, paragraphs can be developed using cause-and-effect reasoning, formal definitions, and comparison and contrast. Each technique suits different kinds of topics and writing purposes.

Formal Letters: Stylistic Forms and Essential Parts

Formal letters follow a distinct style from informal ones, with clear essential parts and specific mechanics of layout. This unit lays the foundation for the more specific formal letter types covered later in the course, such as job applications and letters of complaint.

Formal Letters: Complaints and Request

This unit applies the formal letter format to two common real-world purposes: making a complaint and making a request. Both require clear, polite, and precise language suited to a formal audience.

Module 2: Formal Letters II, Reports, and Summaries

Formal Letters: Jobs, Ordering Goods, and Letters to Organizations

This unit covers writing job application letters (including accepting or declining an offer), letters ordering goods, and letters addressed to government bodies and other organizations — each requiring the appropriate tone and structure for its purpose.

Writing Reports I: Reporting Events

A report is an account of events or experiences, and must be carefully planned with an outline before writing. Every report has three main parts: introduction, body, and conclusion, and should use clear, concrete, precise language, avoiding jargon.

Writing Reports II: Reporting Experiments

Reporting on an experiment follows a specific sequence: plan the experiment, arrange the apparatus, observe, record observations, then write the report. A complete experimental report includes the aim, materials, procedure, observations, and conclusions, sometimes with diagrams or graphs.

Writing Summaries I: Techniques of Summarizing

Summarising requires separating essential ideas from non-essential detail, removing repetition, and paying close attention to the words that link ideas together, since understanding these connections is key to producing an accurate summary.

Writing Summaries II: More on Techniques of Summarizing

Building on Unit 4, this unit stresses identifying the important ideas in a passage and their relationships, then arranging the main points in a proper order using connectives. Regular daily practice is recommended to build summarising skill.

Module 3: Sounds and Speaking

Letters and Sounds in English

English letters and English sounds do not correspond one-to-one — the same letter can represent different sounds in different words. This unit also introduces stress patterns (which affect whether a speaker is understood) and English intonation patterns.

English Vowels and Consonants

This unit covers the vowel sounds and contrasts of English, along with consonant sounds, and how these sounds are correctly recognised and produced. Constant practice is emphasized as the key to becoming a confident speaker.

Interviews

An interview board tests whether a candidate has the right qualities for a role. Strong interview performance depends on knowing your subject matter well, being mentally prepared, being in control of spoken English, and making a good first impression through appropriate dress and presentation.

Seminar Presentation

A seminar is a gathering of experts presenting papers on an important topic, often organized into sessions and sometimes opened by a distinguished guest. Presenters should begin by outlining their major points and link the different parts of their paper clearly.

Public Speech Making

Public speaking follows a three-part structure: an effective opening, a well-organized body, and a strong conclusion. Mastering all three stages helps a speaker hold an audience's attention and communicate clearly.

Module 4: Grammar and Usage

Articles, Concord and Sentences

"A" and "an" are indefinite articles ("an" before vowel sounds, "a" before consonant sounds), while "the" is the definite article. Concord refers to grammatical agreement, especially matching verb forms

like "be," "do," and "have" correctly to number and person. A common error among Nigerian English users is omitting articles where needed, or adding them where they shouldn't appear.

Tenses

Tenses regulate time and show whether an action is ongoing, completed, or will be completed. This unit covers the simple present, present continuous, simple past, past continuous, present perfect, present perfect continuous, and past perfect tenses — and warns against breaking the rule of tense sequence, a common error for Nigerian English users.

Gerunds and Participles

Gerunds are verb forms that function as nouns (e.g. "swimming is good exercise"), while participles are verb forms used as adjectives or in forming compound tenses. Correct use of both is stressed as important for fluent, accurate English.

The Active, Passive and the Infinitive

The active voice creates direct, well-focused statements, while the passive voice shifts focus onto the object of an action and creates a more impersonal tone. The infinitive form of a verb ("to + verb") can appear in different positions within a sentence, each carrying slightly different emphasis.

Modal Auxiliaries

Modal auxiliaries — can, may, must, ought to, should, would — are helping verbs used to express possibility, probability, obligation, and similar shades of meaning. Many Nigerian English speakers use them incorrectly since their native languages don't draw the same distinctions, making careful practice especially important.

Quick Revision Checklist

- Know what a topic sentence is and where it typically appears in a paragraph.
- Be able to name at least 5 transitional devices and what relationship each expresses (result, contrast, addition, etc.).
- Know the three main parts of a report: introduction, body, conclusion.
- Understand the steps for writing an experimental report, in order.
- Know the key techniques of summarising: separating essential from non-essential ideas, removing repetition, tracking linking words.
- Understand why English letters and English sounds do not correspond one-to-one.
- Be able to list what makes a strong interview performance.
- Know the three-part structure of a public speech.
- Understand the difference between indefinite articles (a/an) and the definite article (the), and when each is used.
- Be able to identify at least 6 modal auxiliaries and what each can express (possibility, obligation, etc.).
- Understand the difference between active and passive voice, and when each is appropriate.
- Know what gerunds and participles are and how they function in a sentence.